

Evaluating lexical countability with count-mass gender*

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1. Introduction

This paper examines whether there is a distinction between count and mass nouns, henceforth Lexical Countability ($\pm$ LC). As early as Sharvy 1978, doubt has been cast on whether this traditional distinction is in fact a feature of English, and the question is continuously debated relative to additional languages and empirical domains (Borer 2005, Doetjes 2012, Deal 2017, Nakamura 2023, Kagan 2023).

We evaluate the question of Lexical Countability with the novel empirical domain of count-mass polysemy with varying gender in Maceratese. Gender is a property of nouns, so gender correlating with countability is potentially insightful about the role of countability in the meaning of nouns. We argue that the count-mass gender is most naturally accounted for in a framework which distinguishes between count and mass nouns (+LC).

This paper is organized as follows. Section 2 introduces count-mass gender in Maceratese, where certain nouns control for N(euter) or M(asculine) agreement, henceforth N-M doublets. We argue that the gender opposition encodes a distinction which hitherto was not identified as grammatically encoded, between mass (kinds) vs. count (kinds). The first notion covers (i) kinds which are instantiated by uncountable instances plus (ii) instances thereof, and the second covers (i) kinds which are instantiated by countable instances plus (ii) instances thereof. Thus, Maceratese indicates that any framework of countability should make this distinction. Section 3 argues that the $-$ LC frameworks of Borer (2005) and Pelletier (2012) do not, i.e., Maceratese poses a challenge to two implementations of $-$ LC. Section 4 argues that the count-mass gender is most naturally accounted for in a +LC framework where, in the context of N-M doublets, N and M respectively realize the universal grinder (Pelletier 1975) and the universal packager (Bach 1986). Section 5 is the conclusion.

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2. Count-mass gender in Maceratese

This section introduces count-mass polysemy with varying gender in Maceratese, which the next sections argue is most naturally accounted for in a +LC framework.

Maceratese is an Italo-Romance variety where N(euter) has two associations with masshood. First, although there is M(asculine) and F(eminine) plural inflection, there is no N plural inflection. Consequently, neuters are incompatible with elements which select for plural nouns, e.g., *du* ‘two’. This is shown in (1) with N vs. M.PL *caffè* ‘coffee’, our first example of a N-M doublet. Due to its inflectional class (Paciaroni 2012), *caffè* does not exhibit gender or number stem alternations, but these features are visible in targets of agreement, e.g., the adjective *colombian*{*o, i*} ‘Colombian{N, M.PL}’ in (1).

- (1) Du *caffè* *colombian* -{**o, i* }.
 two coffee Colombian -{N , M.PL }
 ‘Two Colombian coffee(s).’

The second association between N and masshood is that the meaning of each neuter involves unindividuated stuff. For example, the meaning of N *caffè* involves unindividuated amounts of coffee (beans, grounds, or liquid). We shortly explicate what “involves” means.

The two associations between N and masshood are potentially insightful about the role of uncountability in the meaning of nouns. Additionally, Maceratese might offer insight about countability. This is because one third of neuters have a M counterpart which is pluralizable and has count meaning (Paciaroni 2012).¹ For example, (1) shows that M *caffè* is pluralizable, and we next show that its meaning involves coffee servings.

Contrary to N *caffè* ‘coffee’ being ruled out in (1), both N and M are acceptable in (2). However, M expresses a stronger proposition: it entails that a serving of coffee was heated, whereas N is compatible with a non-serving amount of coffee being heated.

- (2) So *scallato* I -{**o, u* } *caffè*.
 AUX.PRS.1SG heat.PTCP the -{N , M.SG } coffee
 ‘I heated the coffee {N stuff, M serving}.’

Example (2) exhibits a perfect correlation between gender and countability. On one hand, M *caffè* has the count meaning of ‘serving’, and it is morphosyntactically countable, e.g., it is pluralizable and modifiable by numerals. Conversely, N *caffè* in (2) has the mass meaning of ‘stuff’, and it is unpluralizable (because N lacks plural inflection).

Note that we did not write that N *caffè* is uncountable altogether. This is because the correlation between N and uncountability breaks down with kinds. As background, kinds are notionally countable in the sense that they can be counted, e.g., *Caturra* and *Typica* are two kinds of coffee. Thus, if the correlation in (2) were to continue, then the reading ‘kind

¹The difference between neuters with and without a masculine counterpart is diachronic (Loporcaro 2018, Schoenfeld and Palmieri to appear).

of coffee’ should only be available to *M caffè*. Instead, this reading is available to both genders, with a predictable difference in meaning. Consider (3):

- (3) Qual adè l -{o, u } caffè più car -{o, u } che
which be.PRS.3SG the -{N, M.SG } coffee most expensive -{N, M.SG } that
c’ete?
have.PRS.2PL
‘What’s your most expensive coffee {N variety, M serving}?’

The difference in meaning between the N and M variants in (3) is illustrated with answers. N is answerable with the name of a coffee plant, e.g., *Lo Caturra* ‘Caturra’, but not with the name of a coffee serving, e.g., *Lu creminu co lo ghiaccio* ‘coffee cream with ice.’ Conversely, M is answerable with the latter, and to the extent that *Lo Caturra* is an acceptable answer, it can only mean ‘serving made with Caturra.’ Thus, M unambiguously asks about kinds of servings, whereas N unambiguously asks about different kinds, defined next.

The semantic difference in (3) is systematic with (2). The relation between the two uses of *M caffè* in (2–3) is that the latter ranges over kinds of coffee servings, and the former ranges over instances of such kinds, i.e., concrete coffee servings. The two uses of N have a parallel relation: *N caffè* in (2) ranges over unindividuated amounts of coffee (beans, grounds, or liquid), and in (3) it ranges over kinds which are instantiated by such amounts. For example, Caturra as a kind is instantiated by amounts of Caturra beans in any state of matter. We call the latter “mass kinds” (Chierchia 2010).

Mass kinds are crucial to identifying what N corresponds to in N-M doublets. First, mass kinds (like all kinds) are notionally countable, and *N caffè* in (3) ranges over such kinds, so N does not correspond to notional uncountability. Second, mass kinds show that N does not correspond to morphosyntactic uncountability. This is because when *N caffè* ranges over mass kinds, it is compatible with *quarsiasi* ‘any’, which is shown in (4) to select for singular count nouns.

- (4) Poli sceglie quarsiasi {foglia, *foglie, *fogliame }.
can.PRS.2SG choose.INF any {leaf, leaves, foliage }
‘You can choose any {leaf, *leaves, *foliage}.’

Following (4), (5) shows that the singular count *quarsiasi* ‘any’ is compatible with *N caffè* ‘coffee’. Thus, N does not correspond to morphosyntactic uncountability.²

- (5) Qui vennemo quarsiasi caffè colombian -o.
here sell.PRS.1PL any coffee colombian -N
‘Here we sell any kind of Colombian coffee.’

²Neuters without masculine counterparts, e.g., *vi* ‘wine’, are incompatible with *quarsiasi* ‘any’, e.g., **quarsiasi vi* cannot mean ‘any kind of wine’ (Schoenfeld and Palmieri to appear).

Mass kinds indicate that in the N-M doublet *caffè* ‘coffee’, N does not correspond to notional or morphosyntactic uncountability. It instead corresponds to a notion which covers both mass kinds and their instances, henceforth “mass (kinds)”. We thus identify the N-M opposition in *caffè* as corresponding to mass (kinds) vs. count (kinds), where the latter covers (i) kinds which are instantiated by countable instances, aka count kinds (Chierchia 2010), plus (ii) instances of count kinds. To our knowledge, this is the first observation of grammatical encoding of mass (kinds) vs. count (kinds).

We next show that N-M corresponds to mass (kinds) vs. count (kinds) with the additional N-M doublet of *pesce* ‘fish’. The importance of considering this noun alongside *caffè* ‘coffee’ is that under the traditional distinction between count and mass nouns, *fish* is count and *coffee* is mass. Thus, the N-M polysemy of *caffè* and *pesce* can be insightful about whether these nouns differ in Lexical Countability.

First, N *pesce* ‘fish’ in (6) means ‘fish meat’, and M means ‘fish specimen’. As before, M is morphosyntactically countable, and N is not when it ranges over unindividuated amounts of fish meat. (*Pesce* does not exhibit gender or number stem alternations.)

- (6) Adè rriat -{o , u } l -{o , u } pesce.
 AUX.PRS.3SG arrive.PTCP -{N , M.SG } the -{N , M.SG } fish
 ‘The fish {N meat, M specimen} has arrived.’

Next, the N-M opposition in (6) extends in a predictable way to the kinds in (7): N unambiguously asks about kinds of fish meat, and M unambiguously asks about kinds which are instantiated by fish specimens (fish varieties for short). The N and M variants are respectively appropriate in a fish restaurant and in a pet shop.

- (7) Qual adè l -{o , u } pesce più car -{o , u } che
 which be.PRS.3SG the -{N , M.SG } fish most expensive -{N , M.SG } that
 c’ete?
 have.PRS.2PL
 ‘What’s your most expensive fish {N meat, M variety}?’

As before, mass kinds break the correlation between N and two notions of uncountability. First, N *pesce* ‘fish’ in (7) ranges over notionally countable kinds of fish meat, so N does not correspond to notional uncountability. Second, N *pesce* is compatible with the singular count *quarsiasi* ‘any’ in (8), so N does not correspond to morphosyntactic uncountability. Instead, as with N *caffè* ‘coffee’, N corresponds to mass (kinds).

- (8) Qui vennemo quarsiasi pesce nostran -o.
 here sell.PRS.1PL any fish local -N
 ‘Here we sell any kind of local fish meat.’

In conclusion, N-M corresponds to mass (kinds) vs. count (kinds) with both *caffè* ‘coffee’ and *pesce* ‘fish’. As for whether these nouns differ in Lexical Countability, note that N and M.SG inflections are equally formally complex, *-o* and *-u* respectively. Thus, there is no

morphological indication that M *caffè* ‘serving’ is derived from N ‘stuff’, nor that N *pesce* ‘meat’ is derived from M ‘specimen’. Therefore, this polysemy is perhaps naturally accounted for in –LC framework. However, the next sections argue that the –LC frameworks of Borer (2005) and Pelletier (2012) are ill-suited.

3. –LC

This section argues that the –LC frameworks of Borer (2005) and Pelletier (2012) cannot suitably account for the data in Section 2. This is because in these frameworks, the countability distinction does not correspond to mass (kinds) vs. count (kinds). Consequently, the most straightforward adaptation makes incorrect predictions, detailed next.

First, the countability distinction of Borer (2005) is the presence vs. the absence of the classifier head in the nominal structure. Specifically, a nominal with and without a classifier head respectively has divided (countable) and undivided (uncountable) reference. The latter is the basic sort of reference of all nouns, i.e., this is a –LC framework where all nouns are mass. The most straightforward adaptation of this framework to N-M doublets is that N and M respectively correspond to the absence vs. the presence of the classifier head.

Crucially, the countability distinction of Borer (2005) also corresponds to morphosyntactic (un)countability. This is because all nominal elements of countability require the classifier head, including singular count determiners like *quarsiasi* ‘any’. Thus, if N were to correspond to the absence of the classifier head, then it would be incorrectly predicted that N *caffè* ‘coffee’ and N *pesce* ‘fish’ should be incompatible with *quarsiasi* ‘any’.³ This is contrary to (5) and (8), where these neuters range over mass kinds. Thus, the challenge to the –LC framework of Borer (2005) is that it lacks a straightforward way to distinguish between (mass) kinds vs. count (kinds).

Continuing to the –LC framework of Pelletier (2012), its countability distinction consists of the features +MASS and +COUNT. The background to what these features do is that all nouns basically range over all (un)countable entities which fit their descriptive content, i.e., all nouns are both count and mass. With that, +MASS and +COUNT respectively remove all countable and uncountable entities from the noun’s denotation. The most straightforward adaptation of this framework to N-M doublets is that N and M respectively correspond to +MASS and +COUNT. However, this makes two incorrect predictions.

First, if N (+MASS) were to remove all countable entities from the noun’s denotation, then it would be incorrectly predicted that N *caffè* ‘coffee’ and N *pesce* ‘fish’ should not be able to range over kinds. This is contrary to (5) and (8), where these neuters range over mass kinds. This incorrect prediction stems from +MASS corresponding to notional uncountability, whereas N is compatible with notionally-countable mass kinds.

Second, if the only effect of M (+COUNT) were to remove all uncountable entities from the noun’s denotation, then it would be incorrectly predicted that M *caffè* ‘coffee’ and M *pesce* ‘fish’ should be able to range over any countable entity which fits their descriptive content. However, these M nouns cannot range over mass kinds: M *caffè* in (5) cannot range over kinds of coffee plants, and M *pesce* in (8) cannot range over kinds of fish meat. This

³Recall from fn.2 that this prediction is borne out for neuters without M counterparts.

incorrect prediction stems from +COUNT corresponding to notional countability, whereas M actually corresponds to the narrower notion of count (kinds), which excludes mass kinds.

Unlike the preceding adaptation of Pelletier 2012, the data in Section 2 is accounted for if (i) M (+COUNT) removes mass kinds and their instances from the noun's denotation, and (ii) N (+MASS) removes count kinds and their instances. However, this contradicts the aspect of Pelletier's framework where a count determiner (like *quarsiasi* 'any') marks a nominal as +COUNT. This would lead to the contradiction where a neuter with *quarsiasi* is both +MASS and +COUNT. Thus, the challenge to the -LC framework of Pelletier (2012) is that it too lacks a straightforward way to distinguish between (mass) kinds vs. count (kinds).

In conclusion, N-M doublets in Maceratese pose a challenge to two implementations of -LC, which differ in whether all nouns are (i) mass (Borer 2005), or (ii) both count and mass (Pelletier 2012). The next section argues that +LC fares better.

4. +LC

This section argues for a +LC account of the data in Section 2 where count-mass polysemy stems from three operations: the universal grinder (Pelletier 1975), packager (Bach 1986), and sorter (Bunt 1985). These respectively derive (i) the 'meat' reading of animal nouns, (ii) the 'serving' reading of substance nouns, and (iii) the taxonomic reading (Krifka et al. 1995). We do not rely on specific definitions of these operations (Chierchia 2010), and we notate them as GRIND, PACK, and SORT.

We next recast the data in Section 2 in a way which appeals to the trio of operations. First, PACK and SORT derive the four readings of *caffè* 'coffee' in the manner summarized in (9). SORT ◦ PACK in (9d) is logically possible in any framework with SORT and PACK, but we are not aware of previous appeals to this composition. Thus, N-M doublets in Maceratese provide the first known argument for a framework which allows SORT ◦ PACK.

(9)	a.		COFFEE	'stuff'	(2) N
	b.	PACK	COFFEE	'serving'	(2) M
	c.	SORT	COFFEE	'variety'	(3) N
	d.	SORT	PACK	COFFEE	'kind of serving' (3) M

Next, GRIND and SORT derive the four readings of *pesce* 'fish' in Section 2 in the manner summarized in (10). As before, SORT ◦ GRIND in (10d) is logically possible in any framework with SORT and GRIND, but this is the first appeal that we know of to this composition.

(10)	a.		FISH	'specimen'	(6) M
	b.	GRIND	FISH	'meat'	(6) N
	c.	SORT	FISH	'variety'	(7) M
	d.	SORT	GRIND	FISH	'kind of meat' (7) N

With the role of the trio of "universal" operations in place, the question arises regarding the role of gender. Following recent discussion on whether gender asserts or presup-

poses meaning (Sudo and Spathas 2020), Section 4.1 argues against N and M presupposing (un)countability, and Section 4.2 argues that they assert (un)countability by respectively realizing GRIND and PACK in the context of N-M doublets.

4.1 Presupposing (un)countability

This subsection argues against an analysis where (i) M and N respectively presuppose countability and uncountability, and (ii) the trio of “universal” operations are available to satisfy the presuppositions. This analysis works for nouns which are basically countable, but not for ones which are basically uncountable.

The preceding analysis works for the basically countable *pesce* ‘fish’ as follows. First, the only way for it to satisfy the uncountability presupposition of N is via GRIND, which yields (10b) N *pesce* ‘fish meat’. After the presupposition of N is satisfied, SORT can apply to yield (10d) ‘kind of fish meat’. As for M, its countability presupposition is basically satisfied by *pesce*, so no operation is needed, in which case M *pesce* means (10a) ‘specimen’. Lastly, SORT can apply to yield (10c) the ‘variety’ reading.

Continuing to the basically uncountable *caffè* ‘coffee’, this noun basically satisfies the uncountability presupposition of N, so no operation is needed, in which case N *caffè* means (9a) ‘stuff’. After the presupposition of N is satisfied, SORT can apply to yield (9c) the ‘variety’ reading. As for M, one way to satisfy its countability presupposition is via PACK, in which case M *caffè* means (9b) ‘serving’.

The present analysis runs into trouble from the fact that SORT can also satisfy the countability presupposition of M. One would then predict that M *caffè* should be able to mean (9c) SORT (COFFEE). Instead, this reading is only available to N *caffè*, and the only sorted reading of M *caffè* is (9d) SORT $\circ$ PACK (COFFEE). Less technically, one would incorrectly predict that M *caffè* should be able to range over any kind of coffee, but it cannot range over mass kinds. This is the same incorrect prediction as the adaptation of Pelletier 2012 in Section 3; the two analyses differ in $\pm$ LC, but they share the flaw of analyzing M as corresponding to notional countability, although it actually corresponds to the narrower notion of (count) kinds, which excludes mass kinds.

One can maintain that N-M presuppose (un)countability if the following holds: if a noun does not basically satisfy the countability presupposition of M, then only PACK (and not SORT) can satisfy the presupposition. However, it is unclear why PACK and SORT should differ in this way.

Another option is to posit that (i) N presupposes that the noun ranges over mass kinds or instances thereof, and (ii) M presupposes that the noun ranges over count kinds or instances thereof. This however is more ad-hoc than the analysis in the next subsection, where N-M assert (un)countability.

4.2 Asserting (un)countability

This subsection argues for an analysis where in N-M doublets, the genders assert (un)countability by respectively corresponding to GRIND and PACK.

We make a caveat for N-M doublets because M does not always correspond to PACK. For example, M *gelatu* can mean ‘ice-cream stuff’, and M *vitellu* can mean ‘veal meat’, and neither reading utilizes PACK.^{4,5} Whether N always corresponds to GRIND requires a fuller review of N in Maceratese (Loporcaro 2018, Schoenfeld and Palmieri to appear).

In contexts other than N-M doublets, GRIND and PACK are covert, as is their original conception. For example, GRIND is covert in M *vitellu* ‘veal meat’ and F *papera* ‘duck meat’; both nouns exhibit the specimen-meat polysemy of *pesce* ‘fish’, except the readings do not differ in gender. Similarly, PACK is covert in M *gelatu* ‘serving of ice-cream’ and F *virra* ‘serving of beer’; both nouns exhibit the stuff-serving polysemy of *caffè* ‘coffee’, except the readings do not differ in gender.

By analyzing GRIND and PACK as respectively being realized as N and M in the context of N-M doublets, it follows that N *caffè* includes the semantically redundant GRIND, and M *pesce* includes the semantically redundant PACK. We justify this redundancy by conceiving of GRIND and PACK as ways for N-M doublets to satisfy the morphological requirement of having a gender. Thus, the substance nouns M *gelatu* ‘ice-cream’ and F *virra* ‘beer’ satisfy this requirement by being M and F respectively, without GRIND, whereas one way for *caffè* ‘coffee’ to satisfy the requirement is with the semantically redundant but morphologically licensed GRIND. Similarly, the animal nouns M *vitellu* ‘calf/veal’ and F *papera* ‘duck’ satisfy the requirement by being M and F respectively, without PACK, whereas one way for *pesce* ‘fish’ to satisfy the requirement is with the semantically redundant but morphologically licensed PACK.

With the role of gender in place, the present analysis of basically mass nouns like *caffè* ‘coffee’ is summarized in (11), where the only difference from (9) is that (11a, c) include the semantically-redundant but morphologically-licensed GRIND. Similarly, the present analysis of basically count nouns like *pesce* ‘fish’ is summarized in (12), where the only difference from (10) is that (12a, c) include the semantically-redundant but morphologically-licensed PACK.

(11)	a.		GRIND	COFFEE	‘stuff’	(2) N
	b.		PACK	COFFEE	‘serving’	(2) M
	c.	SORT	GRIND	COFFEE	‘variety’	(3) N
	d.	SORT	PACK	COFFEE	‘kind of serving’	(3) M
(12)	a.		PACK	FISH	‘specimen’	(6) M
	b.		GRIND	FISH	‘meat’	(6) N
	c.	SORT	PACK	FISH	‘variety’	(7) M
	d.	SORT	GRIND	FISH	‘kind of meat’	(7) N

As is apparent from (11–12), the present analysis has a straightforward distinction between mass (kinds) vs. count (kinds), thus succeeding where the previous analyses fail. Specif-

⁴Due to their inflectional class (Paciaroni 2012), *gelatu* ‘ice-cream’ and *vitellu* ‘calf/veal’ include the M.SG suffix *-u*.

⁵One can maintain that M always corresponds to PACK by appealing to the distinction between interpreted and uninterpreted gender (Schoenfeld and Palmieri to appear).

ically, M corresponds to count (kinds) by corresponding to both PACK and SORT $\circ$ PACK (SORT does not affect gender), and N corresponds to mass (kinds) by corresponding to both GRIND and SORT $\circ$ GRIND. The output of the latter two operations is respectively uncountable and countable, thus capturing that N does not correspond to uncountability, which challenges the two –LC frameworks in Section 3 as follows.

The adaptation of Borer 2005 in Section 3 incorrectly predicts that neuters in N-M doublets should be morphosyntactically uncountable. By contrast, we capture that they are countable when they range over mass kinds via SORT $\circ$ GRIND, where GRIND is realized as N. Such neuters are unpluralizable (because Maceratese lacks N.PL inflection), but they are compatible with the singular count determiner *quarsiasi* ‘any’, contra the prediction of Borer (2005). Such neuters also range over countable kinds, contra the adaptation of Pelletier 2012 in Section 3, which incorrectly predicts that they should not be able to range over any countable entity.

In conclusion, Section 2 shows that in N-M doublets, neuters range over (i) uncountable amounts of stuff, or (ii) countable kinds which are instantiated by (i). We capture the commonality between (i) and (ii) via GRIND, and the difference with the absence vs. the presence of SORT. With that, the +LC framework with the trio of “universal” operations has a straightforward way of making the distinction encoded by N-M in Maceratese.

5. Conclusions

As early as Sharvy 1978, doubt has been cast on whether English exhibits the traditional distinction between count and mass nouns. Perhaps this doubt is licensed by the relative morphological poverty of English. For this reason, morphologically richer languages are valuable (Kagan 2023), and Maceratese offers the unique value of having count-mass polysemy with varying gender.

At first glance, the count-mass gender in Maceratese seems inconclusive about whether there is a distinction between count and mass nouns: *caffè* ‘coffee’ and *pesce* ‘fish’ can be both count and mass, and each usage controls for gender agreement which is equally formally complex. However, the count-mass gender turns out to have consequences for Lexical Countability, once one identifies what the gender opposition encodes.

Mass kinds are crucial to this identification. They are dualistic in that they are countable, but their instances are uncountable. Thus, if the gender opposition were to encode countability, then nouns ranging over mass kinds should have the count gender of M(ascu-line). Instead, they have the mass gender of N(euter). Thus, the N-M opposition encodes a distinction which cuts across countability: mass (kinds) vs. count (kinds).

Independent of Maceratese, a canonical framework of countability has been developed where there is a distinction between count and mass nouns, and count-mass polysemy stems from a trio of “universal” operations. This framework turns out to have a straightforward way to encode the distinction of mass (kinds) vs. count (kinds): GRIND and PACK correspond to different genders, and SORT does not affect gender. In this way, +LC fares better than the –LC frameworks of Borer (2005) and Pelletier (2012), which lack a straightforward way to distinguish between count (kinds) vs. mass (kinds).

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